CLOTRIMAZOLE

Topical / vaginal

Pregnancy: safe (vaginal)

CHEMICAL NAME 1-[(2-chlorophenyl)(diphenyl)methyl]-1H-imidazole
CLASS Imidazole antifungal (topical)
TRADE NAMES Canesten · Lotrimin · Mycelex (troches)

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Cutaneous candidiasis, tinea pedis, cruris, corporis; pityriasis versicolor; nappy rash with candida.
- Vaginal candidiasis (pessary, vaginal cream).
- Otitis externa (fungal); solution.
- Oral candidiasis (troches/lozenges).

ADMINISTRATION

- **Cream/solution:** apply thinly 2–3 times daily to clean, dry skin; continue 2 weeks after symptoms clear.
- **Pessary:** insert high into vagina at bedtime (use applicator; in pregnancy insert by hand).
- **Troche:** dissolve slowly in mouth.

DOSAGES

- **Skin:** 1% cream 2–3 times daily for 2–4 weeks.
- **Vaginal:** 500 mg pessary once at night, or 200 mg nightly for 3 nights, or 100 mg for 6 nights.
- **Oral troche:** 10 mg 5 times daily for 14 days.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- Minimal systemic absorption from skin and vagina (3–10%).
- Absorbed fraction metabolised in liver.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Inhibits **ergosterol synthesis** → increased membrane permeability → fungistatic/fungicidal.
- Active against dermatophytes, *Candida*, *Malassezia*; some Gram-positive bacteria.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Local burning, stinging, itching.
- Redness, irritation.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Contact dermatitis; allergic reactions (rare).
- Troches: raised liver enzymes (rare).

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Hypersensitivity to clotrimazole or imidazoles.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- Vaginal products may damage latex condoms and diaphragms.
- **Tacrolimus/sirolimus** (troches): ↑ levels.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Teach correct application or insertion technique.
- Inspect skin or mucosa for improvement.
- Advise on hygiene and keeping skin folds dry.
- Recurrent thrush: check for diabetes.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Keep using the cream for 2 weeks after the rash clears.
- Pessary: insert at bedtime; a panty liner helps.
- May weaken condoms — use alternative protection for 5 days.
- Keep feet and skin folds dry; do not share towels.

KEY POINTS

- Topical imidazole antifungal.
- Continue 2 weeks after clearing.
- Skin, vaginal and oral candidiasis; tinea.
- Damages latex condoms.

SOURCES CHECKED [227] Canesten 100mg Pessary (UK SmPC) [228] Canesten 200mg Pessary (UK SmPC) [229] Clotrimazole, oral (US label) *Full references p. 432–457*